

053 Take a footprint plaster cast

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Many wild animals only come out at night, to avoid predators. Often they leave signs of their presence in the form of tracks—and you can preserve these to keep a record of their visits.

What you need

- Posterboard strip 10 x 1½ in (25 x 4 cm)
- Water
- Paper clips
- Mixing bowl
- Plaster of Paris
- Spoon
- Toothbrush



1 Find tracks in soft mud or wet woodland soil. Choose clear ones with the best outlines.



2 Make a ring with posterboard. Secure it with a paper clip. Push the ring into the soil around the track. Mix the plaster until smooth and pour it in the ring.

Match up the print



3 Let set for 30 minutes until it's hard enough to lift. Take it home and let it dry for 24 hours. Brush off any dirt, then use a guide to identify the animal.

054 Identify animal droppings

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Black, tube-shaped droppings, or “scat,” might belong to a fox. Thin, black tubes could be from a cat. Pellet types are probably from deer or rabbits.

FOX



DEER



RABBIT



WILDCAT

